Free painting – intuition

When we paint freely, without a goal and without trying to make a pretty picture, we often reach for brown when we want **something solid**, or on the contrary **something that does not feel like moving**. But we do not always know why. Sometimes we know exactly, sometimes not at all. Both are fine.

What may hide behind a brown stroke

The same brown area on paper can mean **something completely different each time**, depending on what is going on in us. That is why it makes no sense to read a picture like a test with a single right answer.

Support.

Wide earthy areas, often at the bottom beneath the other colours. A wish to have something firm underneath.

Warmth and home.

Caramel and honey tones, round shapes, a roof or a table. A colour with a specific place.

The body.

Chocolate and chestnut areas, a thick trace, a stroke with the whole palm. Sensuality without apology.

Tiredness.

Dull grey-brown areas without light. Something that is certain but tiring.

Stiffness.

Equally brown areas side by side, with no transparency. A feeling that nothing has changed for a long time.

Memory.

Wood, clay, grandma's furniture. A colour that carries scent and touch.

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Brown in a picture. Can it express what is happening inside?

Yes, it **can**, but it **does not have to**. When painting you sometimes reach for a colour before you can name what you feel. Brown can then give shape to warmth, heaviness, physicality, safety and also to something unpleasantly stiff. Equally it can simply be **the colour you had to hand**. It gains meaning only in connection with **your experience**.

A brown picture does not itself say that you need certainty or that you have got stuck in life. Art therapy works with the whole picture and how it came to be. With the situation, memories, the movement of the hand and the feelings during painting. A predominance of brown alone **is not enough for a verdict**.

I want it on the canvas, but I don't dare put it on myself

A picture and a dress ask two completely different things of you. You meet a woman dressed all in brown and it may occur to you that she is older, more serious or more settled. But what do you judge by? Perhaps you formed the impression from a heavy coat and a cut you link with another generation. **You did not read age from the colour.**

The same woman can look completely different in a chocolate dress, a well-cut jacket or a caramel jumper. The brown stayed, its company changed. If you like wearing it but do not want to seem settled, try one change. Add a lighter element near the face, try a lighter material or adorn the outfit with what matches your taste.

You do not have to dress young. The point is that you recognise yourself in your clothes and do not wear out of habit a look that no longer fits. Brown can stay. **Being settled is not a mandatory part of the package.**

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When brown takes over the space

First, let your hand work. **You do not have to paint a tree.** Brown can be a wide area, a translucent layer, a thick trace or a small spot among other colours. The interpretation can wait.

Three things worth noticing

QUANTITY

Support, or a heavy blanket?

A large brown area can pleasantly surround you. At other times you start to want to uncover something of it. A small earthy stroke can tie a picture together. Too similar brown areas may blend, unless blending is just what you want. When you stop, notice whether you want to stay in it, or need to open a space.

SATURATION

Chocolate, or mud?

Chocolate, caramel and grey-brown evoke completely different impressions. If brown seems dull to you, put blue, pink or yellow next to it and compare the impression. If it is too hot and rusty, try a cooler blue or grey companion. Perhaps it is not the colour that bothers you, but the form it has had so far.

THICKNESS

Sometimes the hands need to work

Thick brown can be spread with a spatula, layered, or drawn into. A thin layer lets the ground show through. Sometimes the resistance of the material is just what feels good and you need not look for the right word. For a while it is enough that the hands are doing something and the head does not interfere so much.

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What to take from the picture

It does not matter what a brown stroke looks like. What matters is what you feel while making it and what is going on in your life at that moment. **Two identical pictures can have a completely different meaning**. One arose in a feeling of safety, the other after a long day when you were just holding on. That is why you will not find a dictionary here, but **questions**.

A picture can speak even after time

Perhaps a brown picture will remind you of a period when you were looking for a home. Or of a moment when you finally allowed yourself to rest. At other times you will find no such story in it. Meaning arises in connection with your life, not from a table of brown shades.

Answers often do not come right away

Sometimes you look at what you have painted and it tells you nothing. In a week, a month or a year, though, it may suddenly dawn on you. That is fine. **The painting will wait until you are ready to understand it.**

If very strong or painful feelings appear while painting, do not stay alone with them. Talk about them with someone close or with a therapist. This page does not replace professional care.

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